

blessed with the abundance of talent available to its male counterpart. It has tasted modest success on the continent but has failed to make any serious dent on the world stage. For the women's team, the battle often seems to be both on and off the pitch.

The World Cup arrives against a difficult backdrop for Indian hockey. A former national team captain has levelled allegations of sexual misconduct and criminal intimidation against a coach and Hockey India secretary general Bholanath Singh, respectively. Separately, the change in the colour of the team's jersey has stirred its own controversy.

At one point, even qualification for the World Cup appeared to be in jeopardy following a woeful Pro League campaign that ended in relegation and the departure of the then head coach, Harendra Singh.

In January this year, HI brought in Sjoerd Marijne, who masterminded India's joint-best finish (fourth) at a Summer Olympic Games in 2021, to arrest the decline. The Dutchman has made an instant impact, restoring work ethic, tactical discipline and belief in the group, while securing World Cup qualification and Pro League promotion.

Marijne sees the World Cup as a platform to test his ideas and sharpen the team's conditioning ahead of the crucial Asian Games, with the bigger objective of returning to the Summer Olympics in two years' time.

The immediate challenge is formidable. In its opening pool, India is grouped with China and England, both ranked above it, along with South Africa, the

lowest-ranked side in the tournament. India was outplayed twice by China at last year's Asia Cup under Harendra, while it failed to make the most of its chances in its loss to England in the final of the World Cup qualifiers in March.

Only the top two sides will progress to the second stage, and Marijne will know he has a difficult task on his hands. The performances and results in Australia and the Nations Cup, however, have provided a much-needed morale boost ahead of these crucial two months.

Forward Navneet Kaur's dazzling skills and goal-scoring form over the last 12 months will be vital to India's hopes. Marijne has called for greater efficiency in field goals, but there is a real lack of depth to support Navneet up front. India captain and midfielder Salima Tete will hope she can call on the experience of Savita, Nikki Pradhan, Sushila Chanu and Neha to step up alongside her.

If India somehow manages to get into the second round, things get harder still, with Australia and the Netherlands waiting alongside whichever of China or

England advances.

The co-host and three-time defending champion, the Netherlands, remains a level above the chasing pack. Head coach Raoul Ehren, a long-time business associate of Marijne, has taken a serial winning side and made it

Midfield engine: Belgium's midfield heartbeat, Alix Gerniers will be central to the Red Panthers' hopes on home soil. GETTY IMAGES

